Many of my readers will, I know, be well aware of this Hindutva encroachment of the past and will be as troubled as I am. But for those who are new to this issue, let me explain that as long ago as 1972 that most distinguished historian Romila Thapar,[26] doyenne of the history department of the Jawaharlal Nehru University, spoke out on All India Radio against Indian historians 'serving, consciously or unconsciously, the larger cause of nationalism', describing the negative impact of this historical revisionism as enormous: 'The ancient period became the golden age. The antiquity of Indian civilisation was pushed back by dating the Vedic literature to 4000 BC or even earlier. In order to emphasise the national unity of India since the earliest times generalisations were made on the history of the subcontinent, essentially in the perspective.'[27]

Thirty years later Professor Thapar found it necessary to return to the issue in more specific form. 'History as projected by Hindutva ideologues,' she wrote,

> which is being introduced to children through textbooks and is being thrust upon research institutes, precludes an open discussion of evidence and interpretation. Nor does it bear any trace of the new methods of historical analyses now being used in centres of historical research. Such history is dismissed by the Hindutva ideologues as Western, imperialist, Marxist, or whatever, but they are themselves unaware of what these labels mean or the nature of these readings ... Engineers, computer experts, journalists-turned-politicians, foreign journalists posing as scholars of Indology, and what have you, assume infallibility, and pronounce on archaeology and history. And the media accord them the status.[28]

Since then the pressure from the Hindutva right has, if anything, intensified, as exemplified by the reception given